The desiccation of the Aral Sea

The disappearance of most of the Aral Sea, once the world's fourth-largest lake, in Kazakhstan has been a huge ecological disaster. In the early 1960s, the two main rivers that fed the lake were diverted to irrigate millions of cotton plants across central Asia. In June 2004, the UN warned that the lake could dry up completely unless measures were taken to save it. It was then receiving only 10 percent of the water that it once did, had divided into several smaller lakes, and contained only one-tenth of its 1960 volume of water. Large areas are now desert. Most of the lake's fish and other aquatic life disappeared with its water. Once fishermen here could catch Syr Darya sturgeon, but its numbers declined sharply when the lake shrank and became more saline. Efforts to replenish the waters have achieved an increase in surface area and depth, and fish populations are now increasing.